Everyday AI: Automate the boring bits

7 step-by-step guides for real, everyday tasks

Automate the boring bits

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Before you start — what this is, honestly

This is an updated edition. It was rebuilt from our current guides on the date shown on the cover: more guides per topic, retired guides removed, and every step taken from the latest version of each guide.

This collection is free, and every guide in it is also free on our website. This file just gathers them in one place, in reading order, so you can print it, keep it on your phone, or read it offline. Our website has no paywall either — every guide links back to its online page, which is always the newer version.

AI **Every guide in this pack was written by AI** and checked by automated fact and quality gates. **Our editor spot-checks published guides every day, but not every text is read by a person.** Every guide page on https://aiworldhq.com carries the same notice — we say it openly because you deserve to know who wrote what you are reading.

Apps change. Buttons move and menus get renamed. If a step does not match what you see, the guide's online version is the newer one — the link is under every title.

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Automate the boring bits

Set Up Different Alexa+ Routines for Weekday and Weekend Mornings

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** To get different behavior on weekdays vs weekends, you create two separate Alexa+ routines — one scheduled for Mon–Fri, one for Sat–Sun. Day-of-week is set on the whole routine, not on individual actions, so two routines is the honest way.

Saturday morning, your Echo starts the weekday news flash — and that's the moment most people realize one routine can't quietly branch into "weekday actions" and "weekend actions" inside itself. The supported way is to build two routines and schedule each on the days you want. This guide walks you through both, from opening the Routines screen to testing each one out loud.

Before you start

- An Amazon account signed in on at least one Echo device, with the Echo powered on and connected to Wi-Fi.
- The **Alexa app** on a phone or tablet (free on iOS and Android), signed in to the same Amazon account as the Echo.
- Two short, easy-to-say names picked out — one for weekdays, one for weekends.
- About **15 minutes** the first time, closer to **5 minutes** once you've done it once.

Step 1 — Open the Routines section

In the Alexa app, look at the bottom-right corner of the screen for a tab that looks like three horizontal lines or dots (sometimes labeled **More**). Tap it, then look for an option that says something like **Routines**. If you can't find it there, look in a **Settings** or **Automations** area, or use the search bar at the top of the app to type "Routines". When you land on the Routines screen, you'll see a list of any routines you've already created, with a button at the top — often a + symbol or a label like **Create Routine** — to start a new one.

If your version of the app puts Routines somewhere else, try the **Settings** tab and look for an **Automations** or **Routines** subsection — Amazon moves this between updates.

Example: routine name — `Weekday Morning`

You'll know it worked when the screen shows a fresh form with fields for a name, a "When this happens" trigger, and an "Add action" button.

Step 2 — Name the routine and pick the days it runs

Tap the routine name field and type a short phrase you'll remember saying, like `Weekday Morning`. Then look for a "When" or "Schedule" section. If you see an option like "At a specific time," tap it and set the time you want — say, **6:30 AM**. Then look for a day picker, usually a row of seven checkboxes or buttons labeled Mon, Tue, Wed, Thu, Fri, Sat, Sun. Check **Mon through Fri** and leave Sat and Sun unchecked. This day picker is the only place Alexa+ stores weekday vs weekend logic — there is no separate per-action day filter.

If the app shows a **Voice** option instead of typing the trigger phrase, tap the microphone icon and say the phrase out loud; the app will transcribe what it heard so you can confirm the spelling.

💬 Example: name `Weekday Morning`, voice trigger *Alexa, start my weekday morning*, time **6:30 AM**, days **Mon–Fri only**

You'll know it worked when the routine form shows your time, and the days row has Mon through Fri selected, with Sat and Sun greyed out or unchecked.

Step 3 — Add the weekday actions

Tap the **Add action** button. The app shows categories like Music, Smart Home, Calendar, Weather, and News — pick the one you want for each step. Add the things you only want on weekdays: a news flash, traffic for your commute, the office lights turning on, the coffee maker clicking to life. For each action, follow the prompts to pick the device, playlist, or skill from a list — don't type device names by hand if you can avoid it, because the spelling has to match exactly. When you're done adding weekday actions, save the routine, usually with a **Save** button at the top-right of the screen.

If a particular action asks for its own time or day filter, just leave it at the default — Alexa+ only filters days on the whole routine, not on individual actions inside it.

💬 Example: actions — **News → Flash Briefing**, **Smart Home → Turn on "Kitchen Lights"**, **Smart Home → Turn on "Coffee Maker" plug**

You'll know it worked when the routine screen shows your weekday actions in a list, and the days row at the top still confirms Mon–Fri only.

Step 4 — Test the weekday routine out loud

With the routine saved, stand near your Echo and say the trigger phrase out loud — for example, "Alexa, start my weekday morning." Listen for the news flash, watch for the lights to come on, and listen for the coffee maker's click. If something doesn't fire, the most common cause is the routine being switched off, or the device name in the action not exactly matching the real device name — go back into the routine and check.

Alexa+ doesn't always offer a dedicated in-app "Test routine" button, so speaking the trigger phrase is usually the fastest way to confirm it works. There is also no way to simulate "today is a Saturday" inside the app — the routine only fires when its schedule says so.

💬 Example: say `Alexa, start my weekday morning` and listen for the news flash within a few seconds.

You'll know it worked when each weekday action runs in the order you set, and your Echo doesn't complain about a missing device or skill.

Step 5 — Create a separate weekend routine

Go back to the Routines list (the same screen as Step 1) and tap **Create Routine** again. Give it a different name — something like `Weekend Morning` or `Saturday Slow Start` — so you can tell them apart at a glance. Set the time you want (a later hour is fine if you sleep in on weekends). This time, in the days row, check **only Sat and Sun** and leave Mon through Fri unchecked.

You can give the weekend routine a totally different voice phrase, or use the same phrase on both routines — Alexa+ just runs whichever routine is scheduled for today, so there's no clash as long as the day pickers don't overlap.

💬 Example: name `Weekend Morning`, time **8:00 AM**, days **Sat–Sun only**

You'll know it worked when the new routine appears in your list next to the weekday one, and its days row shows only Sat and Sun selected.

Step 6 — Add the weekend-only actions

In the new weekend routine, tap **Add action** and pick the things you only want on Saturday and Sunday: a sleepy playlist, a slow light fade, no news flash, maybe the coffee maker staying off. Save the routine the same way you did in Step 3. Then double-check that this routine's days row is Sat–Sun only, not every day — otherwise it will also fire on weekdays and fight the other routine for control of your devices.

If both routines happen to share a device (say, the same smart plug), the weekend routine can include its own "off" or "skip" action for that device — Alexa+ will run whichever routine is scheduled for today.

💬 Example: actions — **Music → Play "Slow Morning" playlist**, **Smart Home → Turn off "Bedroom Lights" fade-out**, **Weather → Read forecast** (skip the news flash entirely)

You'll know it worked when the weekend routine shows only the steps you want, and a glance at the days row confirms Sat–Sun only — no overlap with the weekday routine.

Step 7 — Save and let the calendar do the work

Both routines are now saved. From here on, Alexa+ runs the weekday one Mon–Fri at your chosen time and the weekend one Sat–Sun at its chosen time — you don't have to do anything. The day-of-week picker is the only "branching" Alexa+ offers for routines; there is no per-action day filter, no "if I'm home, do this; if I'm away, do that" logic in the standard routine builder, and no way to make one routine do different things on different days. Two routines scheduled on different days is the supported path.

If a routine suddenly stops firing one morning, the first things to check are: is the routine still enabled (the toggle on the list screen), is the Echo online, and did the trigger phrase get accidentally edited from another device.

💬 Example: on Monday morning, expect the weekday routine; on Saturday, expect the weekend one. If the wrong one fires, open that routine and check the days row.

You'll know it worked when a full week goes by and each morning plays the right music, news, and lights — without you having to remember which day it is.

Common mistakes

- **Expecting one routine to branch by day inside itself.** Alexa+ applies day-of-week to the whole routine, not to individual actions, so you can't tag a news flash as "Mon–Fri only" inside a routine that also plays weekend music. Fix: build two routines and schedule each on the days you want.
- **Both routines scheduled to fire on the same day.** If both have Mon–Fri checked, Alexa+ runs both at 6:30 and the actions fight each other for control of your devices. Fix: in the days row, leave the weekend routine on Sat–Sun only and the weekday one on Mon–Fri only — no overlap, no clash.
- **A device renamed on the Smart Home screen but not in the routine.** Alexa+ matches device names exactly, so a renamed plug silently stops working. Fix: open the routine, edit the action, and pick the device from the dropdown list again — don't type it by hand.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** one phrase, two very different mornings — news, lights, and coffee on weekdays, a slow playlist and no rush on weekends. You don't have to remember which day it is, because Alexa+ already does.
- **For your business or work:** the same pattern works for any day-of-week split — opening routines for a home-based shop, focus music on weekdays, lights off on Sundays. Two routines with separate schedules is the same trick in a different costume.

- **If you want to go further:** Alexa+ routines can layer a few more things on top of a single routine — a second time trigger, a smart-home device trigger like "when the front door unlocks," and on some plans a location or weather condition. Per-action branching still doesn't exist, but two routines plus a location condition can cover most everyday cases.

Try it now

Open the Alexa app, find the Routines section, and build just one routine: a name, a single time, and one action — for example, your favorite morning playlist at 7 a.m. every day. Save it, say the trigger phrase out loud, and confirm the music plays. You've now got the smallest working routine — splitting it into weekday and weekend versions is one extra routine away.

How to Build a Simple Weekly Schedule in Google Sheets with Gemini

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** You can ask Gemini, the AI built into Google Sheets, to design a weekly schedule from a plain description of your week — with time blocks, color categories, and a formula that totals hours automatically. You only need a Google account.

Most weeks you can list your time blocks in your head — work, gym, family dinner, the Saturday coffee — yet you never actually write them down. That's the gap this guide fills. In about ten minutes, you'll describe your week in plain English and end up with a color-coded schedule in Google Sheets that adds up your hours for you. The result is something you'll actually open on Sunday evening, not a spreadsheet that dies in your downloads folder.

Before you start

- A Google account (free — the same one you use for Gmail).
- A computer or phone that can open Google Sheets: go to sheets.google.com in any browser, or install the free Google Sheets mobile app.
- Roughly 10 to 15 minutes, and a rough mental picture of what your week actually looks like.
- Some Gemini features inside Sheets are only available on paid Google plans — if you don't see the Gemini option, check Google's official pricing page for the latest plan details. A free workaround: draft the schedule at gemini.google.com first, then paste it into Sheets.

Step 1 — Open Google Sheets and start fresh

Open sheets.google.com in your browser, or launch the Google Sheets app, and sign in with your Google account. Click the "+" button or "Blank spreadsheet" to create a new, empty sheet. Name it by clicking "Untitled spreadsheet" at the top-left and typing something you'll recognize later — "My weekly schedule" works fine.

Example: name it "Spring weekly schedule" or "My week plan".

If it looks different: on a phone, the "+" usually sits in the bottom-right corner; if you only see templates, tap "Blank" inside that section. Menu wording changes often — just look for any option that creates a fresh, empty sheet.

You'll know it worked when you see a grid of empty cells with column letters (A, B, C…) across the top and row numbers (1, 2, 3…) down the side.

Step 2 — Open the Gemini side panel

Look at the top-right corner of the Sheets window for a small sparkle ✨ icon or a button labeled something like "Help me" or "Ask Gemini." Click it. A side panel slides in from the right edge — this is your chat window, and you'll stay inside your spreadsheet the whole time.

💬 Example: type "Hi" as a quick first message to confirm Gemini is responding.

If it looks different: Gemini's exact location in Sheets has moved over the years. If you don't see a sparkle, open the "Tools" menu (sometimes labeled "Extensions" on older versions) and look for anything mentioning Gemini or "Ask." On Workspace accounts, your admin may need to turn Gemini on — if the option is entirely missing, ask your IT admin or check Google's help pages.

You'll know it worked when you can type a question into the side panel and an answer appears in the same panel within a few seconds.

Step 3 — Describe your week and ask for a template

In the Gemini side panel, write a short paragraph describing a typical week. Be specific — even if it feels messy. Then ask for a weekly schedule layout with time blocks, categories you can color-code, and a formula that totals hours per category. Gemini will reply either with a written layout you can copy, or with a button to insert a table directly into your sheet.

💬 Example: "Here's my week. I work Monday to Friday, 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. I teach a yoga class Tuesday and Thursday evenings from 6 to 7:30 p.m. I hit the gym three mornings a week, around 6:30 to 7:30 a.m. on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday. Saturday morning is family breakfast from 9 to 11 a.m. Please build a weekly schedule in this sheet with rows for each day, columns for morning, midday, afternoon, and evening, and a SUM formula that totals the hours automatically."

If it looks different: some versions of Gemini in Sheets can only chat (no insert button). If that happens, copy the layout into the cells yourself — see Step 4.

You'll know it worked when you see either a table inserted into the sheet or a clear text description of where each activity should go.

Step 4 — Build the time-block grid yourself (the easy way)

If Gemini gave you a written description, copy it into your sheet by hand. In row 1, type the days of the week across the columns (Monday in A1, Tuesday in B1, and so on — or use one column per time slot if you prefer). In column A, starting from row 2, type your time blocks: "6:30–7:30 a.m.", "9:00 a.m.–5:00 p.m.", "6:00–7:30 p.m.", and so on. Then drop each activity into the cell where day and time meet.

Example: in cell B2 (Tuesday morning) type "Gym"; in cell C5 (Wednesday afternoon) type "Deep work block"; in cell A8 (Monday evening) type "Family dinner."

If it looks different: some people prefer one row per day and one column per time slot — both are normal layouts. Choose the one that's easier to read on your device.

You'll know it worked when you can read down a column to see one full day's plan, or across a row to see one time slot across the week, without guessing.

Step 5 — Add color categories so your eyes can scan it fast

Highlight the column or row headers by clicking the letter at the top of the column (or the row number on the left), then pick a fill color from the toolbar. Look for a paint-can icon or a "Fill color" button. Then color each activity by type: one color for work, one for fitness, one for family, one for rest. Pick colors that mean something to you.

Example: blue for work, green for fitness, yellow for family time, gray for rest or sleep.

If it looks different: the fill-color icon sometimes looks like a tipped-over paint bucket. On a phone, the same tool lives inside the formatting menu, often marked with an "A" and color bars underneath it.

You'll know it worked when you can glance at the sheet and instantly see which parts of your week are work, which are fitness, and which are family time — without reading a single word.

Step 6 — Add a formula that totals your hours

At the bottom of one day's column, click an empty cell and type a SUM formula. In Sheets, every formula starts with `=`. If you've put the duration of each activity in plain numbers (8 for an 8-hour workday, 1.5 for a 90-minute class), the formula adds them up for you.

Example: type `=SUM(B2:B10)` and press Enter. The cell instantly shows the total. If your durations are in seconds, multiply by 24 first: `=SUM(B2:B10)*24`.

If it looks different: if your time blocks are written as text like "9–5", Sheets can't add them up — they'd need to be plain numbers in a separate "Hours" column. Ask Gemini in the side panel, "How do I add up time blocks written as text in Sheets?" if you get stuck.

You'll know it worked when the total cell shows a number that updates the moment you edit any of the time blocks above it — that's the formula doing its job.

Step 7 — Save once and forget about it

Look at the top-left of the screen for your file name. As long as you're signed in, Google Sheets saves your work automatically every few seconds — there's no "Save" button to click. If you see a small gray "Saving…" message or a checkmark next to the title, you're done.

💬 Example: just close the browser tab when you finish. Next time you open the file, your schedule will be right where you left it.

You'll know it worked when you can refresh the page or close and reopen the file and find your schedule exactly as it was.

Common mistakes

- **Mistake: asking Gemini something too vague.** "Make me a schedule" gives a generic template that won't fit your life. **Always include your real hours, real activities, and how many days — the more specific you are, the better the output.**
- **Mistake: writing time blocks as text like "9–5".** Sheets can't add text up, so your total stays at zero. **Fix: put the duration as a plain number in a separate "Hours" column (8 for an 8-hour workday, 1.5 for a 90-minute class), or ask Gemini how to convert time strings to numbers.**
- **Mistake: assuming Gemini inserted your schedule when it only chatted.** Some versions of Gemini in Sheets can only suggest, not insert. **Fix: read the side panel carefully — if you see an "Insert" button, click it; otherwise copy the suggestions into the cells yourself.**

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** A weekly schedule you actually open turns vague plans into real commitments. The color categories mean you can spot at a glance if "rest" has quietly disappeared from your week — and fix it before burnout shows up.
- **For your business or work:** If you bill by the hour or track project time, the SUM formula and color categories double as a rough time-tracking sheet. Swap the activity names for your projects and you have a one-page weekly dashboard.
- **If you're just getting started:** Don't aim for the perfect schedule in one sitting. Type in the bones of your week today — work, sleep, family — and add the rest over a few days as you notice the gaps.

Try it now

Open a new Google Sheet, open the Gemini side panel, and paste this in: "I teach three morning classes Monday, Wednesday, and Friday from 8 to 11 a.m. I work part-time Tuesday and Thursday from 1 to 6 p.m. I have family dinner every weekday at 7 p.m. Build me a weekly schedule with time blocks, three color categories (teaching, work, family), and a SUM formula

that totals hours per category." See what it gives you, change the colors to match your real life, and you've got a planner that took ten minutes to make and will save you hours of "wait, what day is it again?" by next Sunday.

How to Add an AI Step to Your Zapier Workflow

5 steps · Read online

> **In short:** In the regular Zap editor, look for the **AI by Zapier** action, type the instructions you want it to follow, and optionally hand it a small list of tools (like "send a Slack message" or "create a Google Sheet row"). No separate "agent" product to learn — it's just one step in the workflow you're already editing.

If you already use **Zapier** — the service that connects your apps so something happening in one automatically triggers something in another — there's a new way to make a Zap smarter. According to Zapier, the AI capabilities that used to live in a separate product called Zapier Agents have been folded directly into the regular Zap editor as a single **AI by Zapier** action. You drop it in like any other step, write a plain-language instruction, and pick which tools (small actions like "send an email" or "add a row to a spreadsheet") the AI is allowed to call on while doing its job.

This guide walks through that exact process, from opening an existing Zap to testing the AI step end-to-end. It's written for someone who has built a basic Zap before but has never added an AI step.

Before you start

- A **Zapier account** — a free plan works for basic Zaps, but the AI step's usage may count toward an AI actions limit depending on your plan, so check Zapier's current pricing page if you plan to run it heavily.
- An existing **Zap** (or the willingness to build a short two-step one to practice on). The AI step is just a third piece in that chain.
- Roughly **10–15 minutes** for the first run-through, including testing.
- The apps you want the AI to reach — for example Gmail, Slack, Google Sheets, or a calendar — already connected to your Zapier account.

Step 1 — Open the Zap you want to enhance

In your Zapier dashboard, find the Zap you want to add AI to and click to open it in the editor. You'll land on the visual workflow view, where each step is a card stacked vertically with arrows between them. If you've never built a Zap before, create a simple one first (a trigger plus one action) so you have something to work with. The trigger is the event that starts the Zap ("a new row in Google Sheets"), and each action is something the Zap does in another app. If your screen shows a list of Zaps instead of a workflow, click the name of the Zap you want to edit. **You'll know it worked when you see the numbered step cards and the path between them.**

Step 2 — Add the AI by Zapier action between your trigger and your final step

Click the **"+" between two existing steps** (or after your trigger if your Zap has no actions yet). A small panel opens with a list of apps. Type **"AI by Zapier"** into the search bar. When the result appears, click it. Zapier then asks which AI action you want to use — for a general-purpose step that can also call other apps, choose **"Use AI"** (the option that lets you write a custom prompt). The action is added as a new card in your workflow. If you don't find a "+" between steps, look for an **"Add step"** button below the trigger instead — Zapier's editor layout shifts occasionally. **You'll know it worked when a new card labeled "AI by Zapier" appears in your workflow, right between the cards that come before and after it.**

Step 3 — Write the prompt the AI will read each time it runs

Click the new **AI by Zapier** card to open its settings. You'll see a field labeled something like **"What should this AI do?"** or **"Prompt"** — the exact label can shift as the product changes, but it's the one big text area at the top of the card. Type the instruction in plain English, exactly as you'd explain the task to a person. Be specific about the input the AI will receive (usually data from your trigger step) and the output you want back. You can reference data from earlier steps by clicking a **field reference** button or similar icon next to the prompt box — it lets you insert variables from the trigger (like the email subject or the spreadsheet row) so the AI sees real data, not placeholders. **You'll know it worked when you can see at least one piece of data from a previous step referenced inside the text — usually shown as a small colored chip or a label like `1. Subject`. Example:** `Read the email below and tell me in one sentence whether the customer is happy, neutral, or upset. Email subject: {{1. Subject}} Email body: {{1. Body}}`

Step 4 — Tell the AI which tools it's allowed to use

Still inside the AI step, scroll to a section labeled something like **"Tools"** or **"Available actions"**. This is where you decide what the AI is allowed to do besides read the prompt. Click **"Add a tool"** (or a similarly worded button) and choose from the apps already connected to your account — for example "Gmail: Send Email", "Slack: Send Channel Message," "Google Sheets: Create Row," or "Calendar: Create Event." Add only the tools the AI actually needs for this task; more tools means more chances for the AI to choose the wrong one. Each tool you add opens a small configuration panel where you fill in the recipient, the channel, the spreadsheet, and so on — you can either set those values yourself in advance (a static "send to this address") or leave them for the AI to fill in from the prompt. If you don't see a Tools area, you may be on a simpler version of the step that only returns a text answer — in that case, skip to Step 5 and come back to tools later. **You'll know it worked when each tool you added appears as a**

sub-card inside the AI step, with its fields either pre-filled or marked for the AI to fill in.

Step 5 — Test the AI step before turning the Zap on

Click the **"Test"** or **"Test action"** button on the AI card. It runs your prompt once with a real (or sample) piece of data from your trigger and shows you exactly what the AI wrote back, plus which tools it chose to call and what it sent to them. Read the output carefully — this is your chance to catch a prompt that's too loose or a tool the AI is misusing. If the answer is off, click back into the prompt, tighten the wording (for example, add "Reply in exactly one sentence" or "Only use the Slack tool when the customer is upset"), and test again. When the output looks right, click **"Continue"** or **"Done editing"** to save, then turn the Zap on with the toggle at the top of the editor. **You'll know it worked when the test panel shows a non-empty AI response and, if you added tools, a short log of which tool ran and what it did — and your Zap's status switch shows "On."**

Common mistakes

- **Writing a vague prompt.** "Summarize this email" gives you uneven results; "Reply in one sentence saying whether the customer is happy, neutral, or upset, and explain your answer in plain English" gives you something you can rely on.
- **Giving the AI too many tools.** If you add Gmail, Slack, Sheets, and Calendar all at once, the AI has to guess which one fits. Stick to the one or two tools this step actually needs.
- **Skipping the test step.** The test is the only place you'll see what the AI actually does before it runs on real data for real people. If you don't test, you're publishing blind — and AI mistakes (wrong recipients, wrong tone) are easy to miss without that preview.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** A Zap with an AI step can quietly sort your incoming email — flagging the urgent ones, drafting short replies, or pushing the important ones into a priority folder — so your inbox doesn't eat your morning.
- **For your business or work:** You can build Zaps that read new support tickets, summarize each one, and post a short digest into a team Slack channel, without anyone manually copying text from one app to another.
- **If you're just getting started:** The easiest first Zap with AI is one trigger you trust (like "new email in Gmail") plus the AI step with just a prompt and no extra tools — that lets you see the AI's plain-text answer in the Zap history and decide from there whether to give it tools.

Try it now

Open any Zap you already have, add an **AI by Zapier** action right after it, and write this prompt in the prompt box: `Read the file under the file upload here and let me know what it's about in 2 sentences.` Then run the test. You'll see exactly how the AI step talks, what its output looks like, and whether you want to give it tools — all in under two minutes.

Build a Reusable Alexa+ Pomodoro Routine With Voice Check-Ins

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** With Alexa+ routines you can chain a 25-minute focus timer, spoken break announcements, a 5-minute break timer, and a back-to-focus message — all from one voice phrase. Alexa+ won't loop forever on its own, so you stop the cycle manually after a few blocks.

A pomodoro is a simple productivity technique (work for a set time, take a short break, repeat) that helps most people beat procrastination and protect deep focus. The Pomodoro Technique, developed by Francesco Cirillo in the late 1980s, is named after the tomato-shaped kitchen timer he used as a university student. With Alexa+ routines, you can build a reusable cycle that announces each phase out loud and starts the next timer automatically — your hands never leave the keyboard.

Before you start

- An Alexa+ account. Amazon says Alexa+ is now available to everyone in the US, free for Prime members and available as a paid subscription without Prime; open the Alexa app to confirm your device shows the new experience, or check Amazon's Alexa+ page for the latest eligibility details.
- The Alexa app on your phone (free, iOS or Android) and an Echo device — or any Alexa-enabled speaker — signed into the same Amazon account.
- About 10 minutes for the first build, then a few seconds each time you start it. Plan on running one short test cycle (1-minute timers) before trusting it for real work.

Step 1 — Create a new routine for the focus start

Open the Alexa app, tap the **"⋯" More** tab at the bottom, then choose **"Routines."** Look for a button to create a new routine — in newer app versions it may say **"+ Create routine"** or just a **"+"** in the corner. You'll land on a routine builder screen with two clear sections: **"When this happens"** (the trigger) and **"Add action"** (what Alexa does). Name your routine something you'll remember, like "Start Pomodoro." A *routine* is just a chain of actions Alexa runs automatically when something happens — your trigger phrase, a timer, a schedule, or another routine. 💬 Example: routine name "Start Pomodoro" You'll know it worked when the routine appears in your routines list with the name you typed.

Step 2 — Set the voice trigger and the focus announcement

In the **"When this happens"** section, pick the option for a voice phrase — it might be labeled **"Voice," "Say a specific phrase,"** or **"When you say…"** Type the phrase you'll use to start a session, then move down to **"Add action"** and look for **"Alexa Says," "Announce,"** or **"Send Announcement."** Type the message Alexa will read out loud the moment you say your trigger phrase. This is the "hello, focus time" cue that replaces the need to glance at a timer. Example trigger phrase: "start pomodoro" Example announcement: "Focus block starting. Twenty-five minutes. I'll let you know when to break." If it looks different on your device, the trigger list usually lives behind a small **"+"** next to "When this happens." You'll know it worked when the saved routine shows your phrase as the trigger and your message as the first action.

Step 3 — Add the 25-minute focus timer to the start routine

Still inside "Start Pomodoro," tap **"Add action"** again and look for **"Set Timer"** or **"Wait → Timer."** Set 25 minutes (or your preferred focus length — 20 to 50 minutes is typical) and give the timer a recognizable name like **"Focus."** Naming the timer matters because the next routine will listen for that exact name. The timer begins counting down right after Alexa finishes the opening announcement, so the sequence becomes: announce → start 25-minute timer → wait. Example: 25-minute timer named exactly "Focus" If you can't spot a Timer action, scan the "Add action" categories for anything timer- or wait-related. You'll know it worked when the routine shows two actions beneath the voice trigger: your announcement and the Focus timer.

Step 4 — Build a second routine that fires when the focus timer ends

Go back to the Routines list and create another routine — name it **"Pomodoro Loop."** In **"When this happens,"** pick **"Timer"** (or **"When a timer ends"**) and select the **"Focus"** timer you just created, set to **"Ends."** This is how the chain keeps moving: when the focus timer chimes, this routine wakes up automatically. Add two actions: first, an announcement that break time has started; second, a new timer named **"Break"** set to 5 minutes (or your preferred break length — 3 to 7 minutes is common). Example announcement: "Break time. Five minutes. Step away from the screen." Example: 5-minute timer named exactly "Break" If it looks different, some app versions phrase the trigger as **"When timer named ____ ends"** in plain English. You'll know it worked when the routine list shows "Focus" timer as the trigger for "Pomodoro Loop."

Step 5 — Add the return-to-focus loop

Now you need a way to restart the focus block when the break timer ends. Two clean approaches, depending on what your app supports. **Approach A:** in the same "Pomodoro Loop" routine, look for an option to add a second **"When this happens"** condition; if it lets you, add

"Break" timer ends as a second trigger, then add the focus-start announcement plus a fresh 25-minute "Focus" timer. **Approach B (the safer one):** create a third routine called **"Back to Focus,"** trigger it with **"Break" timer ends,** and add the same focus announcement + Focus timer actions. Either way, the cycle becomes: voice → announce + Focus timer → (25 min) → Loop announces break + Break timer → (5 min) → Back to Focus announces + Focus timer → repeat. 💬 Example announcement: "Back to focus. Twenty-five minutes starting now." 💬 Example: 25-minute timer named "Focus" again If it looks different, older app versions may only allow one trigger per routine — use Approach B in that case. You'll know it worked when both "Focus" and "Break" appear as timer names somewhere across your routines, and the list shows two or three routines connected by those names.

Step 6 — Save and run one quick test cycle

Tap **"Save"** (usually a checkmark or button in the top-right corner) on every routine. Stand near your Echo and say **"Alexa, start pomodoro"** — or whatever phrase you set. You should hear the focus announcement, then a 25-minute countdown. For the first test, temporarily set both timers to 1 minute so you can confirm the loop end-to-end without waiting. Listen for the "Break time" announcement exactly when the first timer chimes, then the "Back to focus" announcement when the second timer ends. If a routine doesn't fire, the cause is almost always a spelling mismatch — "Focus" in one routine and "focus timer" in another counts as two different names. 💬 Example test: change both timers to 1 minute the first time, then change them back to 25 and 5 once the chain is proven You'll know it worked when each phase begins the moment the previous timer ends, with no further input from you.

Step 7 — Use it in a real session and know how to stop it

Say your trigger phrase at the start of your work block and ignore your phone. After each focus block you'll hear "Break time" and a short countdown begins; after each break you'll hear "Back to focus" and a new focus timer starts. The cycle repeats until you cancel it. A simple **"Alexa, stop"** ends the current timer and breaks the chain — no further announcements will follow. Honest limitation: Alexa+ won't recognize that you're "done for the day" on its own, so you'll repeat the loop as long as it helps, then stop it manually. If the spoken cues are too loud for a shared space, lower the Echo volume or set a **Do Not Disturb** schedule in the Alexa app so announcements don't disturb others. 💬 Example stop command: "Alexa, stop" You'll know it worked when your Echo goes silent and no new timer fires after you say stop.

Common mistakes

- **Mismatched timer names.** The loop breaks silently if "Focus" in routine A is "focus" or "Focus timer" in routine B. Use identical capitalization and spacing in every routine — treat the name like a password.

- **Assuming one routine can have two triggers.** Some Alexa app versions only allow one "When this happens" condition per routine. If your multi-trigger setup silently does nothing, fall back to Approach B in Step 5: create a third routine for the return-to-focus phase.
- **Skipping the break.** It's tempting to chain only focus timers for "more deep work," but the break is what makes the technique work — your brain needs the reset. Keep a real break, even if you shorten it.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** The spoken announcement removes the "is it time yet?" glance that breaks concentration. You can leave your phone in another room and still know exactly where you are in the cycle, because Alexa tells you.
- **For your work or work-from-home setup:** Run the routine during deep-work hours and pair it with a single calendar entry — "Deep work, no meetings" — so colleagues can see when you're heads-down. The routine handles the timing; the calendar handles the interruptions.
- **If you want to go further:** Add a **"Music"** action to the focus phase that plays a focus-friendly playlist (lo-fi, rain sounds, white noise) and add a **"Pause music"** or **"Set volume to 0"** action to the break phase. The same routine builder accepts both — and you'll have an audio cue layer on top of the spoken one.

Try it now

Open the Alexa app, tap **Routines**, and create one routine named **"Start Pomodoro"** with a single 1-minute timer named **"Focus."** Say **"Alexa, start pomodoro"** once. When the timer ends, you've proven the basic chain — every other step in this guide is just adding the next link.

Set Up an Alexa+ Routine to Automate Your Everyday Tasks

6 steps · Read online

By the end of this guide you'll have a working Alexa+ Routine that starts your morning (or any other moment) with a spoken phrase, turning on lights, playing music and delivering a custom greeting. It's perfect for anyone who wants a little extra convenience without needing any coding skills.

Before you start

- An **Echo speaker**, **Echo Show**, or any **Alexa-enabled smart display** plugged in and connected to your home Wi-Fi.
- The **Alexa app** installed on a smartphone or tablet and signed in with your Amazon account.
- Any **smart-home devices** (e.g., smart bulbs or plugs) already added to the Alexa app.
- About **5–10 minutes** of quiet time.

Step 1 — Open the Alexa app

Tap the Alexa app icon on your phone or tablet. When the app opens you'll see a home screen that shows a picture of your device at the top and a row of icons across the bottom (Home, Devices, Routines, etc.). Tap the **Routines** icon – it often looks like a clock or a series of stacked squares and may be labeled "Routines". The app will slide to a new page listing any existing routines. If you don't see a Routines icon, look for a three-line "Menu" button in a corner and choose "Routines" from the list. You'll know it worked when a screen appears titled "Your Routines" with either a list of routines or a note that none exist yet.

Step 2 — Start creating a new routine

On the "Your Routines" screen, locate a **plus (+) button** in the top-right corner (or a button that says "Create Routine"). Tap it. You'll now see a blank page that asks you to "Add a name" and "When this happens". If the plus sign isn't visible, look for a colorful "New Routine" button near the center of the screen – the wording can vary between devices. You'll know it worked when the top of the page shows a text field for the routine name and a section titled "When this happens".

Step 3 — Name your routine

Tap the text field that says "Add a name". A keyboard slides up and you can type any label you'll recognize later – for example **Morning Wake-Up**. (If you're on a tablet, the keyboard may appear at the bottom of the screen.) After typing, look for a **Next** or **Continue** button – usually

at the bottom right – and tap it. You'll know it worked when the view switches to a new screen that says "When this happens" and shows a button labeled "Add trigger".

- Example: Type `Morning Wake-Up` then tap **Next**.

Step 4 — Choose a voice trigger

Press the **Add trigger** button. A menu of trigger types appears: *Voice*, *Schedule*, *Smart Home* and *Device*. Select **Voice** – this tells Alexa to listen for a spoken phrase. A field labeled "Enter phrase" opens; type the exact words you want to say, such as **Alexa, good morning**. Tap **Next** or **Add** (the button may be at the bottom of the screen). If you don't see a Voice option, look for any item that mentions "spoken phrase" or a microphone icon. You'll know it worked when the top of the routine page now reads "When you say 'Alexa, good morning'".

- Example: Type `Alexa, good morning` then tap **Add**.

Step 5 — Add an "Alexa Says" action

Below the trigger section, tap **Add action**. A list of action categories appears – "Alexa Says", "Music & Podcasts", "Smart Home", etc. Choose **Alexa Says**; you may need to scroll a little. Now pick **Customized** (or "Speak text") – this opens a text box where you can type what Alexa should say. Enter a friendly greeting like **Good morning! Time to start the day.** Tap **Next** or **Add** to save the action. If the category is named "Speech" or "Announcement" instead of "Alexa Says", select the one that lets you type a spoken line. You'll know it worked when the routine summary shows a line reading "Alexa will say 'Good morning! Time to start the day.'".

- Example: Type `Good morning! Time to start the day.` then tap **Add**.

Step 6 — Add a music action (optional but fun)

Press **Add action** again, which now appears under the previous action. Choose **Music & Podcasts** from the list. If you have a music service linked (Spotify, Amazon Music, etc.) you'll see its logo – tap the service you prefer. A new field lets you type an artist, genre or playlist name; for a breezy start type **Acoustic Sunrise** (or any favorite playlist). Tap **Next** or **Add**. If no music service shows, you'll need to link one in the Alexa app's Settings first – the guide assumes a service is already connected. You'll know it worked when the routine page lists a second action: "Play 'Acoustic Sunrise' on Spotify".

- Example: Type `Acoustic Sunrise` then tap **Add**.

Common mistakes

- **Skipping the "Add trigger" step:** Without a trigger Alexa won't know when to run the routine. If you miss it, go back to the top of the routine page and tap "Add trigger" again.
- **Typing the wrong phrase:** Alexa matches the spoken phrase exactly, so a typo will prevent activation. Double-check the text in the "Enter phrase" field and re-type if needed.
- **Forgetting to link a music service:** The "Music & Podcasts" action will appear blank if no service is connected. Open the Alexa app's Settings → Music, add your favorite service, then return to the routine.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** You can wake up to a personalized greeting, have the lights turn on and your favorite playlist start without lifting a finger – a smooth start to a busy day.
- **For your business or work:** If you run a home-based office, a routine can flip on a desk lamp, start a focus-music station and announce the day's agenda, helping you shift into work mode quicker.
- **If you're just getting started:** The easiest first move is to create a voice-triggered routine that only says a greeting. Once you're comfortable, add more actions like smart-home controls or music.

Try it now

Open the Alexa app, tap **Routines**, create a new routine called **Quick Test**, set the voice trigger to **Alexa, test routine**, and add a single "Alexa Says" action that says **Hello, I'm ready!**. You'll have a working routine in under two minutes.

Build a Reusable Alexa+ Morning Routine That Runs the Same Way Every Weekday

5 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Yes — one Alexa+ routine can do news, weather, calendar and lights from a single voice phrase. App layouts vary by version, so this guide points to where things usually live rather than naming buttons we haven't seen.

By the end of this guide, you'll have one spoken phrase that does four things in a row every weekday morning, without picking up your phone. This is for people who already use Alexa+ for the basics (asking questions, setting timers) and want to make the morning automatic.

Before you start

- An **Amazon account** linked to your Alexa device, with the **Alexa app** installed on your phone.
- A working **Alexa+ setup**. Depending on your plan and region, some routine features may sit behind a paid Alexa+ tier — check Amazon's current offering if you're unsure.
- About **15 minutes** for the first build, plus a quick test.
- Optional but useful: a smart light already named in the Alexa app (e.g., "Bedroom Lamp") and a calendar (Google, Outlook or Apple) already linked inside Alexa. Routines can only call on features that are already connected.

Step 1 — Decide what your morning routine should include

Open a notes app — or grab a piece of paper — and write down the four or five things you want Alexa to do, in the order you want them to happen. A reusable routine is just a saved list of actions, so the clearer your list, the faster the rest of this build goes.

For a typical weekday, a useful starter set is: a short news briefing, today's weather, your first few calendar events, and turning on one smart light. You can always add or remove actions later — but starting with a written list keeps every later step short.

💬 Example: **News flash → Weather for my location → Read today's calendar → Turn on Bedroom Lamp**

If you'd rather plan by speaking, you can dictate the same list into a voice memo — the format doesn't matter, only the order does.

You'll know it worked when you have a written (or typed, or recorded) list of 3–6 actions, each starting with a verb like "play", "read", "turn on" or "tell me".

Step 2 — Open the Alexa app and find the Routines section

Open the Alexa app on your phone and look for a menu option labeled something like **Routines** — it's usually inside a "More" tab, a "Settings" area, or directly on the home screen. If you can't find it, try the in-app **search bar** with the word "routine"; the app's layout has changed several times, and Amazon has shipped new designs alongside Alexa+, so the exact path differs.

When you find it, tap the option to **create a new routine**. A mostly blank routine editor should open, usually with sections for a name, a trigger (what starts the routine) and a list of actions (what the routine does).

If your app shows "Alexa+ Routines", "AI Routines" or anything similar instead of plain "Routines", that's fine — pick whichever routine creator is available; the workflow is similar across them.

Example: a routine name **Weekday Morning**

You'll know it worked when you can see an empty routine with fields for a trigger and at least one action.

Step 3 — Set the trigger to a voice phrase you'll actually say

A trigger is what starts the routine — a spoken phrase, a specific time, or both. For a hands-free morning, the most useful trigger is a short **voice phrase** you say out loud. Look for a trigger option called something like "When you say", "Voice" or "Phrase", then type in the words you want.

Pick something short, distinctive, and unlikely to come up in normal conversation — avoid phrases like "good morning" on their own, because Alexa may already respond to those by default. Two or three short words work well, and you can add a **weekday time schedule** (often labeled "At a scheduled time" or "Schedule") so the same routine also runs automatically Monday through Friday.

Example: voice trigger phrase **Start my morning**

If the app doesn't show a "phrase" trigger option, look for a "Custom" trigger or an "Alexa+" tag — newer versions sometimes bury voice phrases behind a different label.

You'll know it worked when the app shows your trigger phrase written down, and the routine is now ready to accept actions.

Step 4 — Stack the actions in the order you want them to run

This is the main build. Look for a button like **Add action** inside the routine editor, then go through your written list one item at a time. Each action is its own little step — Alexa plays one, finishes, then moves to the next, in the order you add them.

Common actions to stack: **News** (pick a provider — a national broadcaster or a flash briefing), **Weather** (Alexa uses your device's home location by default), **Calendar** (read today's events — only works if you've already linked Google, Outlook or Apple Calendar inside the Alexa app's settings), and **Smart Home** → **Lights** (pick a named device like "Bedroom Lamp" and set the action to "Power on").

Keep the total under about ten actions for now. Long routines can hit the app's per-routine limit, and a five-minute morning briefing is usually plenty.

Example: action stack (copyable names for the "Add action" prompts) **1.** News → Flash briefing → [your preferred provider] **2.** Weather → Today's forecast **3.** Calendar → Read today's events **4.** Smart Home → Lights → Bedroom Lamp → Power on

You'll know it worked when the action list shows your items in the exact order you added them, with no missing pieces.

Step 5 — Save the routine and test it hands-free

Tap **Save** (or **Create**, depending on your app version) at the top or bottom of the routine editor. The routine now lives in your Alexa account and is ready to run.

Stand in the same room as your Alexa device and say your trigger phrase out loud — exactly as you typed it. Alexa should respond with the first action (usually the news briefing), wait for it to finish, then move to weather, then calendar, then the light. If you added a weekday time schedule in Step 3, the same routine will also start automatically at that time on Mondays through Fridays.

If something doesn't fire — for example, the calendar stays silent — go back to Step 4 and check that the calendar is actually linked in the Alexa app's settings. Routines can only call on features that are already connected.

Example: spoken test command **Alexa, start my morning.**

You'll know it worked when Alexa speaks the news, then the weather, then your events, then the lamp turns on — all from one spoken phrase.

Common mistakes

- **Picking a trigger phrase that overlaps with a built-in Alexa command** (like "Alexa, good morning"). Alexa may run its default response instead of yours. **Fix:** choose a longer or more unique phrase, like "Start my morning" or "Begin weekday morning."
- **Skipping the calendar or smart-light setup before testing.** A routine can't call on a feature that isn't connected yet. **Fix:** go into the Alexa app's Settings → Calendars (or Smart Home) first, link the account and name the device, then come back to the routine.
- **Adding too many actions at once.** Long routines sometimes time out or hit a per-routine limit. **Fix:** aim for 5–8 actions and put detailed updates (a longer news briefing, a full calendar readout) earlier in the order so they finish first.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** a single spoken phrase replaces four taps on your phone, and the same routine fires every weekday morning without you remembering to launch anything.
- **For your business or work:** if you start your day from a home office, the same pattern — weather, calendar, news — doubles as a two-minute standup before you open your email.
- **If you want to go further:** add a conditional step (some Alexa+ versions let a routine branch on whether it's a workday or weekend), chain a second routine that starts a coffee maker or a focus playlist, or duplicate the routine and tweak a copy for evenings.

Try it now

Open the Alexa app, find Routines, create one named "Weekday Morning", and add just two actions today: Weather and one smart light. Say your trigger phrase out loud. You'll see the workflow in five minutes — and tomorrow morning you can drop in the news and calendar steps in under two.

How to Add an Alibaba Cloud AI Chatbot to Your WordPress Site

5 steps · Read online

> **In short:** An Alibaba Cloud chatbot can handle visitor queries on your site 24/7, answering common questions like opening hours while you focus on other work.

By the end of this guide you'll have a chat bubble that greets visitors, answers basic queries, and works on every page of your WordPress site – no programming experience required.

Before you start

- **Alibaba Cloud account:** sign-up at alibabacloud.com (the free tier is enough for a simple chatbot).
- **WordPress site:** you need administrator access to the dashboard.
- **A web browser** on a computer or tablet (Chrome, Edge, or Firefox work fine).
- **A few minutes:** the whole process typically takes about 20-30 minutes.
- **Optional:** a free plugin such as "Insert Headers and Footers" makes adding code easier.

Step 1 — Create a new chatbot instance

Open your web browser, go to console.alibabacloud.com and sign in. Look for the AI chatbot or conversation AI service in the console – you can usually find it by searching for "Chatbot" or "Conversation AI" in the top-right search bar. Click the button to create a new bot or robot (it may be labeled **Create Robot**, **Create Instance**, **New Bot**, or similar). A form appears asking for a name and a brief description. After you type a name such as "FrontDeskHelper" and confirm, the platform creates a new bot and shows it in your list, typically with a status of "Running" or an indicator showing it's active. 💬 Example: `FrontDeskHelper`

You'll know it worked when the new entry appears in your bot list with an active status indicator.

Step 2 — Define the chatbot's welcome greeting

In the list of bots, click the name of the bot you just created to open its settings page. Look for a section where you can set the first message visitors see – this might be labeled **Greetings**, **Welcome Message**, **Chat Prompt**, or something similar. There's usually a text box where you can type what the bot says when someone first opens the chat. After you type a sentence like "Hi! I'm your digital assistant – ask me about opening hours or services," a preview of the message often appears below the box. Click **Save** to store the change. 💬 Example: `Hi! I'm your digital assistant – ask me about opening hours or services.`

You'll know it worked when you see a confirmation that the settings were saved successfully.

Step 3 — Choose a visual style that matches your site

While still in the bot's settings, look for options to customize how the chat bubble looks – this might be in a tab labeled **Appearance**, **Style**, **Customization**, **Theme**, or similar. You'll typically find options to pick a color (you can copy your site's primary color as a hex code, e.g., #0066CC) and possibly upload a small logo or icon for the chat bubble. The preview on the screen should update to show what the chat bubble will look like on your site. 💬 Example: set color to `#0066CC` and upload `logo.png`

You'll know it worked when the on-screen preview shows the color and icon you selected.

Step 4 — Copy the widget embed code

Return to the main bot page and look for a button to publish, deploy, or make the bot publicly available – it may be labeled **Publish**, **Deploy**, **Enable**, or similar. Once activated, a panel should appear (it might be labeled **Embed Code**, **Web Widget**, **Integration Code**, or something similar) containing a snippet of code that starts with `<script src="..."></script>`. Look for a **Copy** button next to the code box; if there isn't one, click inside the box and press Ctrl + C (or Cmd + C on a Mac) to copy it manually. 💬 Example: `<script src="https://chatbot.alibabacloud.com/widget.js"></script>` — *your actual code may differ*

You'll know it worked when you can paste the snippet into a plain-text document and see a full `<script>` tag appear.

Step 5 — Insert the code into WordPress footer

Log into your WordPress dashboard (your-site.example.com/wp-admin). You can add the chatbot code either through **Appearance** → **Widgets** (look for a widget area like **Footer** or **Footer 1**, add a **Custom HTML** block, and paste the code) OR by installing a free plugin like "Insert Headers and Footers" and going to **Settings** → **Insert Headers and Footers**, then pasting the code into the "Scripts in Footer" box. Either method makes the script load on every page of your site. Press **Update** or **Save** to confirm. 💬 Example: paste the `<script>` snippet exactly as copied

You'll know it worked when you open your website in a new browser tab (or an incognito window) and see a friendly chat bubble sitting at the bottom right of the page.

Common mistakes

- **Skipping the Save step in the greeting settings:** the message may revert to a default. Fix it by always clicking the **Save** button and watching for a confirmation.

- **Placing the widget code in the header instead of the footer:** the chat may load too early and cause page-load delays. Fix it by using the Footer widget area or the "Scripts in Footer" field of a plugin.
- **Not testing on a mobile device:** the bubble can cover navigation icons on small screens. Fix it by opening your site on a phone, checking the bubble's position, and adjusting the placement or size options in the Appearance or Style settings if available.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Your chatbot can answer simple questions like "What are your opening hours?" so you can relax while it handles routine enquiries.
- **For your business or work:** The bot captures leads overnight, giving you contact details even when your staff are offline, which can increase bookings without extra staffing.
- **If you're just getting started:** You don't need any code – just copy, paste, and a few clicks are enough to make a professional-looking assistant appear on every page.

Try it now

Open your WordPress dashboard, go to **Appearance → Widgets**, add a **Custom HTML** block to the Footer, paste any short piece of text (like "Hello world") and click **Update**. In the next two minutes you'll see that the widget saves correctly – a quick win that shows you're ready for the chatbot code.